Dossier Space Pilot — Governing Principle

Perfect Until It Is Not: The Transparent-Exception Principle

3 August 2026 · Ken Tombs (whose formulation this is) with Claude (design lead, Opus 4.8) · The governing principle for how the scorecard and primers treat imperfection. It corrects the meaning of the AND-gate across the rubric and the dissonance note. → reference (Master Reference: Architecture / Foundational concepts).

> ***"All is perfect until it is not — then we want to know why, obviously and transparently."***

1. The principle

The default state is SILENCE. When the axes trade cleanly — which is most of the time — the framework says nothing, gets out of the way, and lets the work stand: no ceremony, no notation, no flags. Perfect until it is not.

The moment something does NOT trade cleanly — a coupling cost, a bypass state, an axis that cannot clear its threshold, an unresolved tension — the framework's only job is to make that visible: obviously and transparently. Not to judge it, not to void it, not to resolve it. Surface it, where no one can miss it and no one has to dig for it. The "why" is announced, not buried.

2. Why this inverts the usual instinct — and why that is right

Most quality systems are LOUD everywhere — endless attestations, checkboxes, green ticks on everything — and thereby HIDE the single red flag in a sea of green. Dossier Space does the opposite: silent on the perfect, vivid on the flawed. The exception announces itself, so the flaw is the only thing demanding attention when it appears. Signal, not noise. A framework that attests loudly to everything trains its readers to skim; a framework that speaks up only at its own seams trains them to look exactly where looking matters.

3. What this corrects: the AND-gate is an alarm, not a guillotine

This principle revises the meaning of the scorecard's conjunctive gate. The gate is NOT a guillotine that voids a run the moment an axis falls below threshold. The axes DO trade, and usually trade cleanly; when they do, the gate is silent and the run stands. The gate is an ALARM: it stays quiet while all holds, and sounds the moment an axis cannot clear — telling you WHY, obviously and transparently, so a human can look at exactly the thing that needs looking at.

The run therefore remains USABLE. The framework never makes the usability decision; it makes the imperfection impossible to overlook and hands it to human judgement (matter-appropriate, per the per-matter threshold). Unclean trades are surfaced, notated (e.g. the coupling notation "X=4, Y=3 (coupled −1)"), and — crucially — kept usable, routed to the Agentic (Z) layer where the residue is made interrogable. Never hidden, never falsely resolved, never automatically voided. An evidential framework that discarded every imperfectly-traded run would be useless in practice, because real evidence work is MADE of imperfect trades.

4. How it fits the dissonance account

This completes, rather than contradicts, the dissonance reframing (see "The Axes as Dissonance-Managers"). If the axes manage IRREDUCIBLE tensions, then of course they sometimes cannot be satisfied cleanly at once — that is what irreducible means. A guillotine gate would throw away exactly the runs where a real tension surfaced — often the most evidentially interesting ones (the hanging-thread / bypass case being the clearest: a run whose Y-axis did not "complete" cleanly is MORE evidentially valuable, not disqualified). The transparent-exception principle is what keeps such runs usable: the imperfection is surfaced and interrogable, the human weighs it, the work stands or falls on judgement rather than on an automatic rule. The framework's job is to be silent when things hold and unmissably clear about why when they do not.